Dialogue System Guide

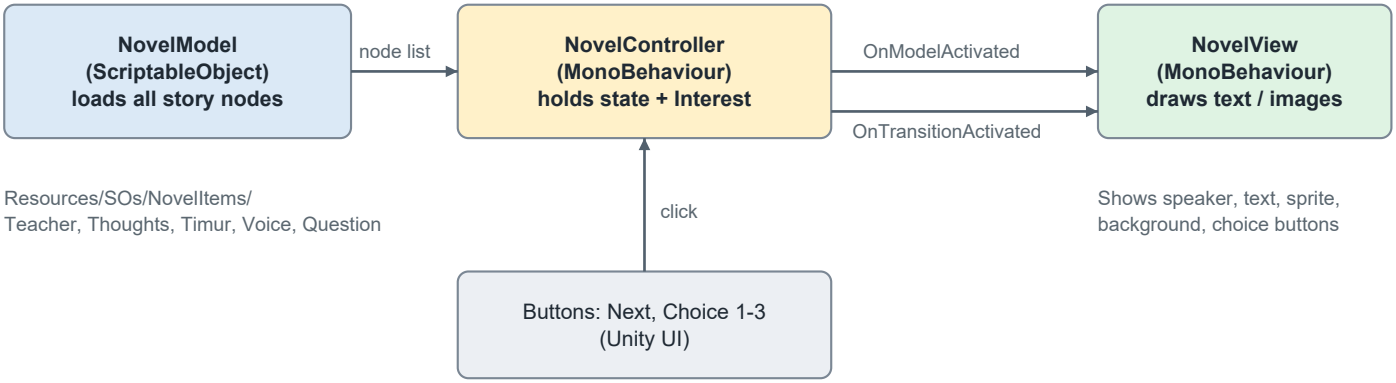
How the visual novel's story, choices and interest score work in Unity

What this system does

The novel is a **graph of small ScriptableObject assets**. Each asset is one "node": a line of dialogue, a choice, a chapter title, or an invisible interest gate. Every node points to the next one. A single runtime component, **NovelController**, walks the graph one click at a time and tells **NovelView** what to display.

There is no script per scene. All story content lives in data assets under `Assets/Resources/SOs`, so writers can add scenes without touching code.

In one picture

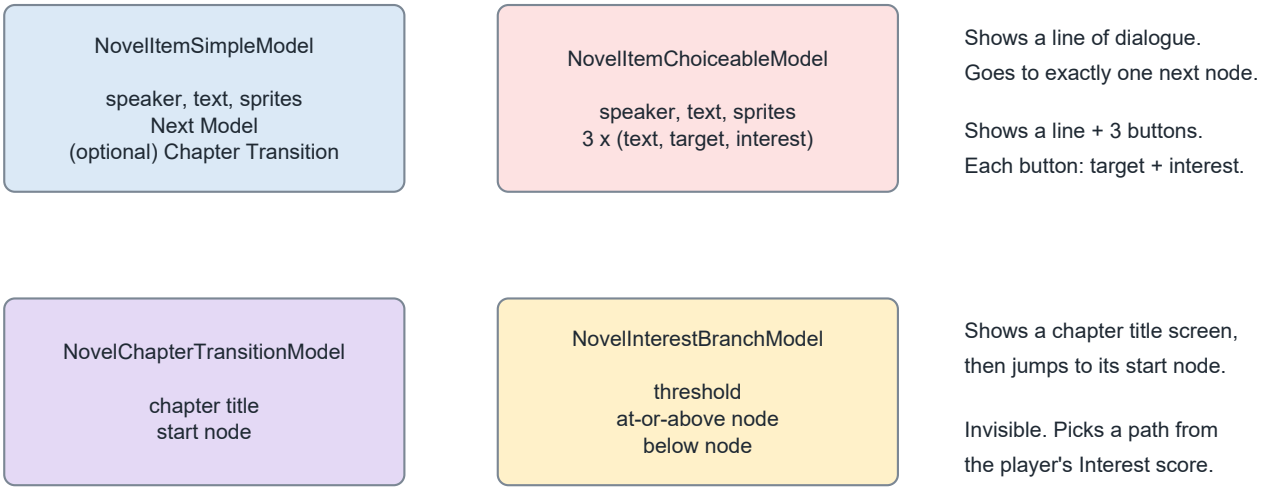


The three runtime pieces

Piece	File	Responsibility
NovelModel	NovelModel.cs	Loads every story item from `Resources/SOs/NovelItems/{Teacher, Thoughts, Timur, Voice, Question}` when the scene starts.
NovelController	NovelController.cs	Holds the current node, advances the story on every click, wires the choice buttons, keeps the **Interest** score.
NovelView	NovelView.cs	Listens to controller events and updates texts, character sprite, background, choice buttons and chapter fade.

1. Node types

Everything the story contains is one of four asset types. Create them from the Unity menu **Assets > Create > SOs**.



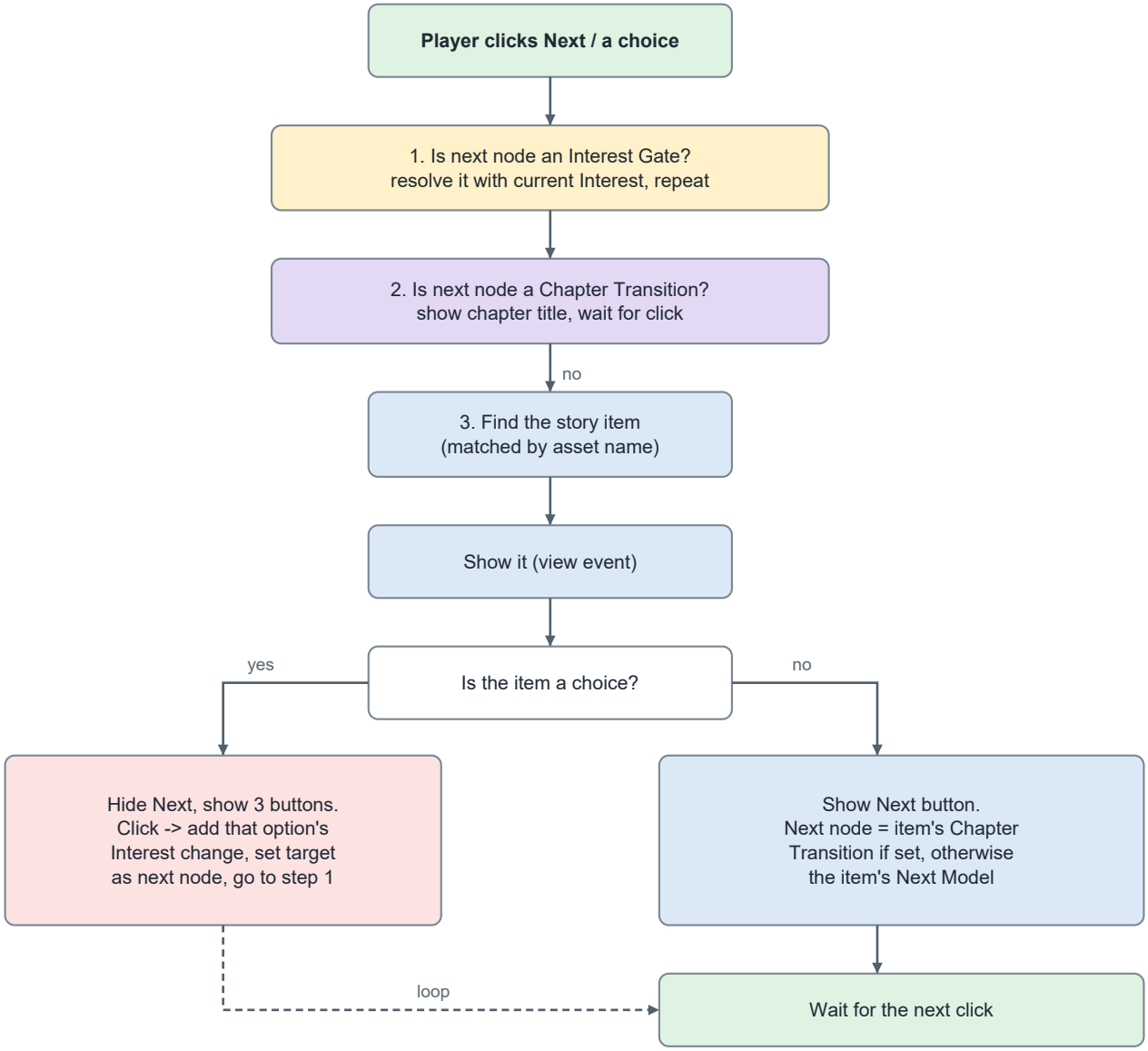
Asset	Main fields	Notes
NovelItemSimpleModel	Name Text, Speach Text, Character Sprite, Background Sprite, Character Anim Trigger, **Next Model**, Chapter Transition Model	A normal line. If **Chapter Transition Model** is set, it wins over Next Model (used to end a chapter).
NovelItemChoiceableModel	Same as above, plus First/Second/Third **Choice Model** (target), **Choice Text** and **Choice Interest** (a number)	Shows the line and three buttons. The Next button is hidden until a choice is made.
NovelChapterTransitionModel	Chapter Title, Start Novel Model	Full-screen chapter title that types out, fades, then starts the chapter.
NovelInterestBranchModel (gate)	Threshold, At Or Above Model, Below Model	Not shown to the player. Chooses the next node by comparing the player's Interest with the threshold.

Rules that matter

- **Asset names must be unique.** The controller finds the item to show by comparing asset names, so two assets with the same name will confuse the flow.
- Story items (Simple / Choiceable) must live in one of the five folders under `Resources/SOs/NovelItems`, otherwise NovelModel will not load them. Chapter transitions live in `Resources/SOs/Transition`; gates in `Resources/SOs/Gates`.
- A node whose **Next Model** is empty ends the story at that point.
- Naming convention: `TimurSpeach_0412`, `ThoughtsSpeach_0404`, `VoiceSpeach_0409`, `Question_0402`. The first digit after the underscore is the chapter number.
- Speakers: **Voice** = narration ("..."), **Thoughts** = Aika (and her inner monologue), **Timur** = Timur, **Teacher** = the lecturer, **Question** = choice nodes.

2. How one click moves the story

Every click on the Next button, and every click on a choice button, runs the same method: `NovelController.StepNovelProgression()`.



If the next node is empty (null), the story stops: the Next button does nothing.

3. Choices and the Interest score

A choice node offers up to three buttons. Each button stores three things in the asset:

- the **text** on the button,
- the **target node** the story continues with,
- an **interest change** (a whole number, positive, negative or 0).

When the player clicks a button the controller adds that number to **Interest** (Timur's interest in Aika) and continues from the chosen target. The total starts at 0 every time the novel scene starts. Anything can subscribe to `OnInterestChanged` to show a meter or play an effect.

Example asset (Question_0400, choice 4.1)

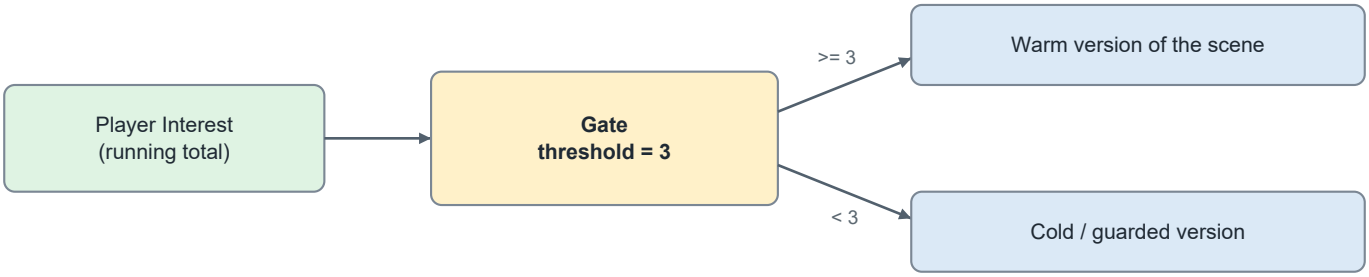
Button	Text	Goes to	Interest
1	"Что случилось?"	Gate_0401	+1
2	"Мне все равно. Я просто иду домой."	TimurSpeach_0409	-1
3	"Не знаю, что там у тебя, но сидеть тут в одиночку - тупо."	TimurSpeach_0411	+1

Why two options often continue to the same place

Many choices only change how Timur reacts and how the Interest score moves, then the story rejoins. That keeps the graph manageable while still letting choices matter later through gates.

4. Interest gates

A gate is an invisible node. When the controller reaches it, it compares the current Interest with the **Threshold** and silently continues to one of two nodes. Use gates in front of key scenes so the same story can have a warm and a cool version.

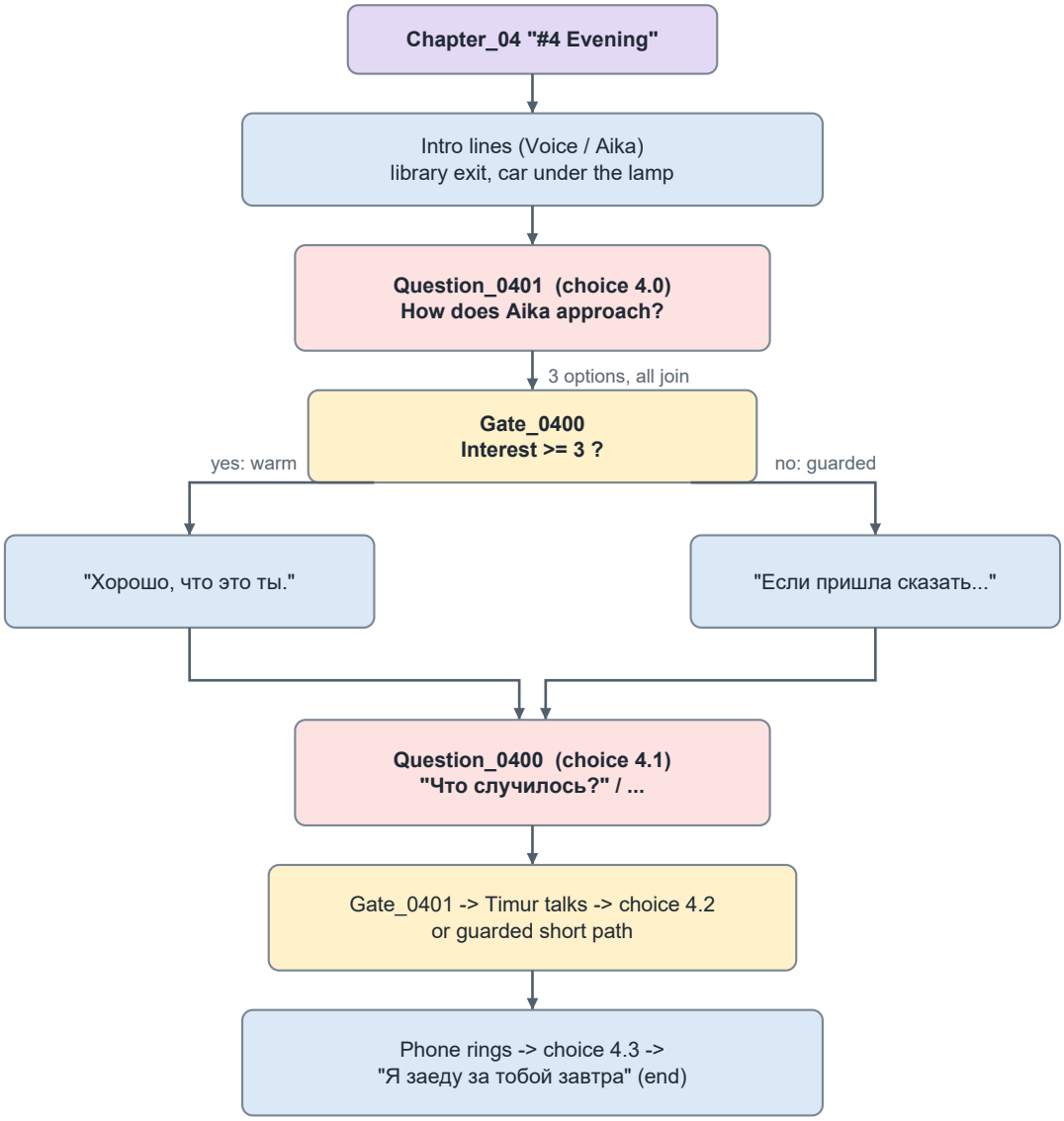


The controller resolves gates in a loop, so a gate can point to another gate. Thresholds currently in use:

Gate	Threshold	At or above	Below
Gate_0400	3	Timur opens up at once ("Хорошо, что это ты.")	Timur stays defensive
Gate_0401	2	Timur tells about his father	Timur deflects ("Ничего.")

5. Worked example: Chapter 4

This is a simplified map of one chapter. Blue = dialogue, red = choice, yellow = gate, purple = chapter title.



Chapter 4 has about 50 nodes; the diagram collapses straight runs of dialogue into one box.

6. How to add new story

Adding a dialogue line

- Create a **NovelItemSimpleModel** in the right folder (for example `Resources/SOs/NovelItems/Timur`).
- Give it a unique name, fill in **Name Text** and **Speach Text**, and set the sprites you want.
- Set **Next Model** to the node that should follow. Previous nodes must point to this new node.

Adding a choice

- Create a **NovelItemChoiceableModel**. Fill in the three **Choice Text** fields, the three **Choice Model** targets, and the three **Choice Interest** numbers.
- Every option needs a target. An empty target logs a warning and the button does nothing.

Adding a chapter

- Create a **NovelChapterTransitionModel** with a title and the first node of the chapter.
- On the **last** dialogue line of the previous chapter, set **Chapter Transition Model** to the new transition.

Adding an interest gate

- Create a **NovelInterestBranchModel**, set **Threshold**, **At Or Above Model** and **Below Model**.
- Point the previous node (or a choice option) at the gate instead of at the scene directly.

Known limitations

- The node-graph editor window (`Assets/Editor/NovelGraph`) only draws dialogue, choice and chapter nodes. **Gates are not drawn**, and links to them do not appear. Do not rewire a link that points to a gate from that window.
- Only one score (Interest) exists. There are no flags such as "went to the dinner" yet.
- Dead ends are not detected automatically. A node with an empty Next Model silently ends the story. Eight library endings used to do this and now continue into Chapter 4.
- Interest only affects the story where a gate is placed.
- A choice can hold at most three options.

Current content

Chapter	Scene	Status
1 Class	Teacher asks, Timur ignores, first look	Done
2 Coridor	Timur asks for help, the money choice	Done
3 Library	Late arrival, phone, Mercedes/Porsche, beauty choice	Done, large branching scene
4 Evening	Parking lot, Timur's honesty, father's call	Done, first scene with interest gates
5 and later	Invitation to his world, parents, ideal girl, big fight, growth, ending	Planned